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California Legislature kills and weakens bills in final push

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The final, frenetic week of the Legislature is as much about bills that don't get through — or get watered down significantly — as those that do pass and reach Gov. Gavin Newsom's desk, or the big, last-minute deals:

* Legislative staff unionizing: Past efforts to allow California legislative staffers to unionize have failed for at least 23 years. But Assembly Bill 1 passed the Senate Tuesday and will head to the governor after a final sign-off from the Assembly, explains CalMatters' state Capitol reporter Sameea Kamal. To get that far, compromises were made. New lawmakers, for example, could dismiss their predecessor's staffers. And in July the bill was amended to delay when staffers could organize from 2024 to 2026. Still, the bill's author, Democratic Assemblymember Tina McKinnor of Inglewood, was happy with the results and has "faith" Newsom will give his go-ahead. For more on the measure, including what its critics say, read Sameea's story.

* Climate change: A first-in-the-nation bill that would require companies that make more than $1 billion in annual revenue to disclose greenhouse gas emissions has been weakened before reaching the governor, according to CalMatters' climate reporter Alejandro Lazo. SB 253 would give the 5,300 covered companies that do business with California until 2030 before they would be fined for inaccurately reporting data for certain indirect sources of emissions. And emission reports from suppliers and consumers wouldn't begin until 2027. Also, oil companies successfully turned a proposal that would have tripled fines on air pollution, into a two-year bill, reports The Mercury News.

* UC labor standards: The University of California breathed a sigh of relief as a proposal to amend the state constitution and require the UC to conform to the same labor standards as other public agencies failed to advance out of a Senate committee Monday. The proposal has been backed by labor groups, but Democratic Sen. Steve Glazer, chairperson of the Senate elections and constitutional amendments committee, said during the hearing that it would create an "incredibly slippery slope" that would jeopardize the independence of the UC.

A reminder that CalMatters is tracking bills that are being sent to Newsom. Tuesday, that list grew:

* SB 447, by Senate President Pro Tem Toni Atkins, would replace a state travel ban to states with anti-LGBTQ laws with a promotional fund to encourage tolerance.

* AB 316, by Democratic Assemblymembers Cecilia Aguiar-Curry of Davis and Laura Friedman of Burbank, would put limits on big, self-driving trucks.

* SB 423 and SB 4, both by Democratic Sen. Scott Wiener of San Francisco, would make it easier to build housing.

* SB 389, by Democratic Sen. Ben Allen of Redondo Beach, spells out the state's powers to investigate water claims.

* AB 418, by Democratic Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel of Woodland Hills, would ban some chemicals in food — but not the one that made it known as the "Skittles ban."

* AB 5, by Democratic Assemblymember Rick Zbur of Santa Monica, would require teachers to undergo annual training to support LGBTQ students. And SB 760, by Democratic Sen. Josh Newman of Fullerton, would require schools to have at least one gender-neutral bathroom, beginning in 2026.

* SB 2, by Democratic Sen. Anthony Portantino of Glendale, would maintain some of California's concealed-carry

weapons laws after a U.S. Supreme Court ruling last year.

* Two bills from Atkins seek to close remaining gaps in California's abortion protection and access network. SB 487 would prohibit health insurers and the state from penalizing abortion providers who have been sanctioned in other states. SB 385, already signed into law, would allow trained physician assistants to conduct surgical abortions without direct supervision by a physician.

CalMatters covers the Capitol: CalMatters has guides to keep track of your lawmakers, explore the Legislature's record diversity, make your voice heard, understand how state government works and to find out what Gov. Newsom decides on key bills.

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